Chapter 9 · Story

Friendship begins with the quiet shift.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

A newcomer hopes to make friends. What is a respectful starting point?

A Offer a shared activity and notice reciprocal interest.

B Share increasingly private details until closeness develops.

C Keep arranging contact after invitations are declined.

Suggested answer: A. Offering a shared activity creates an opportunity to connect. Notice whether the other person also chooses to participate and shows interest.

Shared settings create opportunities.

- **Proximity**: closeness creates opportunities to meet.
- **Similarity**: shared interests can support conversation.
- Sam and Leo share a shift and an interest in old radios.
- Connection still depends on mutual willingness.

A shared shift creates opportunities

1. **Sam and Leo meet on Thursdays**
   Proximity changes who becomes familiar
2. **They discover an interest in radios**
   Similarity can support conversation
3. **They choose further conversation**
   Look for reciprocal interest
4. **Either person can set a boundary**
   Contact creates no right to friendship

Connection is possible, not guaranteed.

Shared settings create opportunities, with mutual willingness.

Familiarity has conditions and limits.

- **Mere exposure effect**: repeated encounters can increase liking in some conditions.
- An unfamiliar face may become more comfortable to see.
- Repetition can also intensify annoyance or threat.
- A stated boundary still matters.

Repeated encounters can have different effects

Possible familiarity



A face becomes more comfortable to see.
Liking may increase.

A different response



Unwanted contact can intensify annoyance or threat.
More is not automatically better.

The mere exposure effect depends on conditions.
A stated boundary still matters.

Familiarity has limits and does not override boundaries.

Closeness depends on the response.

- **Disclosure**: sharing something personal.
- **Responsiveness**: helping someone feel understood and cared for.
- **Reciprocity**: mutual consideration over time.
- Check what support is wanted before offering advice.

Closeness depends on the response

1. **Leo discloses something personal**
   “It has been a difficult week.”
2. **Sam listens and checks understanding**
   “Have I understood what you mean?”
3. **Sam asks what support Leo wants**
   Listening, practical help, or advice?
4. **Reciprocity over time**
   Mutual consideration, not matching secrets

Disclosure needs willingness and responsiveness.

Connection depends on what each person wants and how the other responds.

Respond to the preference someone states.

- Attachment describes patterns studied in close relationships.
- Labels are not diagnoses.
- Sam’s refusal states a preference for now.
- Leo can accept it and leave future contact optional.

A declined invitation is useful information

What Sam says



“I need time alone.”
An expressed preference for now.

Leo’s response



Accept the refusal.
Leave future contact optional.
One occasion does not establish an attachment style.

Attachment labels describe studied patterns.
They are not diagnoses or permission to persist.

Leo can respect Sam’s preference without inferring an attachment style.

What can we really conclude?

Much relationship research examines associations or asks people to report their own experiences. Self-reports provide information about those experiences, but people may remember events differently or answer in ways they prefer others to see. Samples may also represent only particular cultures or relationship forms. Suppose similar partners report greater satisfaction. That association does not, by itself, establish that making two people more similar would improve their relationship. Other factors might contribute to both similarity and satisfaction. To apply that research to Sam and Leo, first ask about their actual experiences and preferences. Their conversations may reveal relevant details that a group average cannot settle. A research pattern cannot decide what either person should want.

An association and an individual relationship

Study reports



Some partners report greater similarity and satisfaction. Self-reports can have limitations.

Sam and Leo’s situation



Ask Sam and Leo about their experiences and preferences. A group average cannot choose their goals.

Association alone does not establish an intervention. Ask about the pair’s actual experience.

Use research to frame questions, then ask about Sam and Leo’s own experiences and preferences.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Sam declines an invitation and needs time alone. What should Leo do?

A Diagnose an avoidant attachment style.

B Accept the boundary and leave future contact optional.

C Increase contact to use the familiarity effect.

Suggested answer: B. Accepting the invitation refusal respects Sam’s stated preference without inventing a diagnosis.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> How can proximity affect friendship?

> Why is disclosure alone insufficient?

1. Proximity changes opportunities to interact and discover shared interests.

2. Disclosure alone is insufficient because willingness, responsiveness, trust, context, and mutual boundaries also matter.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

During a willing everyday conversation, ask an open question. Summarize what you heard and invite the person to correct your summary before offering advice. Afterwards, reflect on your own responses and the feedback the person actually gave.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.